Companies, Holdings, Trusts and Wealth Structures

A purpose-led map of legal ownership, liability, governance, tax, succession and reporting.

MATRIX REPROGRAMMED - DETAILED WEALTH GUIDE

Reader outcome: Create a structure decision memo and reject complexity without a documented purpose.
Best for: A reader deciding whether a company, holding structure, property vehicle, trust, foundation or family arrangement solves a real problem.
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Educational information only. No personalised financial, investment, legal or tax advice. No guaranteed outcomes.

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1. Structure follows purpose

Begin with the legal, commercial, financing, family or governance problem - not the structure name.
List assets, liabilities, owners, beneficiaries, decision rights, cash needs and jurisdictions.
Compare the simplest lawful arrangement capable of solving the problem.
Include setup, annual compliance, professional fees, banking friction and exit cost.

2. Personal ownership and individual business

Personal ownership may be simple and transparent but can expose the owner to concentration, succession and liability issues.
An individual business can reduce administration while remaining unsuitable for partners, outside investment or certain risks.
Understand which assets and liabilities are legally separate under current law.
Keep business and personal records operationally separate even where the legal form is simple.

3. Operating company

An operating company contracts, employs, invoices, owns assets and bears business risk.
Review share rights, director authority, distributions, payroll, solvency and reporting.
A company does not remove personal guarantees, director duties or unlawful conduct.
Retained profit belongs to the company, not automatically to the shareholder personally.

4. Holding company

A holding company may own subsidiaries, investments or intellectual property and allocate capital between them where lawful.
Potential purposes include risk separation, reinvestment, acquisition, governance and succession.
Model tax on contributions, dividends, sales, interest, management charges and extraction.
Document real services and avoid artificial circular transactions.

5. Property company or SPV

A special-purpose vehicle may isolate one property or project for lenders and partners.
Compare financing, tax, transfer cost, personal guarantees, accounting and exit flexibility with direct ownership.
A company wrapper does not remove vacancy, maintenance, title or planning risk.
Decide ownership and exit before acquisition, not after value has increased.

6. Trust

A trust separates legal control and beneficial interests under duties defined by applicable law and documents.

Potential purposes include succession, vulnerable beneficiaries, long-term stewardship and conditional distributions.

Trust recognition, taxation, disclosure and control vary sharply by jurisdiction.

A trust is not a secrecy device and may create extensive reporting obligations.

Assess trustee competence, independence, fees, powers, removal and dispute process.

7. Foundation and charitable structures

Foundations can pursue charitable or defined long-term purposes under specific legal regimes.

Family, charitable and operating foundations have different governance and tax treatment.

Assets dedicated to a purpose may no longer be available for personal use.

Document grant policy, conflicts, investment governance and public reporting.

8. Pension and retirement wrappers

Retirement structures may provide tax treatment, creditor protection or employer contributions subject to access rules.

Compare investment options, fees, beneficiary rules, transfer rights and withdrawal tax.

Do not place short-term liquidity into inaccessible arrangements.

Keep beneficiary nominations and address details current.

9. Beneficial ownership and transparency

Identify legal owner, beneficial owner, controller, director, trustee, protector, settlor and beneficiary accurately.

Maintain required registers and filings.

Do not use nominees or layered entities to mislead banks, authorities or counterparties.

Assume banks, tax authorities and regulators may require full source-of-funds and ownership evidence.

10. Governance

Define reserved decisions, voting thresholds, conflicts, distributions, valuation, death, disability, divorce and exit.

Create access and continuity plans for key documents and accounts without exposing credentials.

Use independent review where one person controls valuation, custody and reporting.

Test whether the structure still works when relationships deteriorate.

11. Structure decision memo

[ ] Problem being solved.
[ ] Assets and liabilities involved.
[ ] Owners, controllers and beneficiaries.
[ ] Jurisdictions and reporting.
[ ] Setup and annual cost.
[ ] Tax at entry, during life and exit.
[ ] Financing and guarantee impact.
[ ] Governance and dispute process.
[ ] Succession and incapacity.
[ ] Simpler alternative.
[ ] Exit cost and unwind process.
[ ] Professional opinions obtained.

12. How to use this guide

Purpose: Create a structure decision memo and reject complexity without a documented purpose.

Best reader: A reader deciding whether a company, holding structure, property vehicle, trust, foundation or family arrangement solves a real problem.

Read the guide once without taking action. On the second pass, complete the checklists and write down the evidence supporting each decision.

Replace every example number with your own verified amount, date, fee, tax treatment, contract term or source document.

Do not treat a checklist tick as proof. Keep copies of the underlying statements, quotations, filings, contracts and calculations.

For major decisions, use this guide to prepare better questions for a regulated adviser, accountant, lawyer, lender or insurer.

13. Evidence standard

Tier 1: law, regulator, tax authority, court, audited accounts, official product document or signed contract.

Tier 2: recognised institutional research that states its methodology, date and limitations.

Tier 3: reputable reporting used to identify questions, not to replace primary evidence.

Tier 4: marketing, social posts, testimonials, screenshots and anonymous claims. Treat these as unverified leads.

Write the source date beside every changing figure. A correct figure without a date can become misleading.

Separate facts, estimates, assumptions and scenarios. Never allow a scenario to be presented as a forecast or guarantee.

A company, fund, adviser, trust, structure, transaction or association is not proof of misconduct.

14. Decision record worksheet

[ ] State the decision in one sentence.
[ ] State the desired result and deadline.
[ ] List the three strongest pieces of supporting evidence.
[ ] List the three strongest reasons the decision may fail.
[ ] Record the maximum acceptable loss of money, time and flexibility.
[ ] Record the smallest reversible test.
[ ] Name the person responsible for checking legal, tax or regulatory consequences.
[ ] Set the next review date and the evidence that would cause you to stop.

15. Professional advice triggers

Seek regulated investment advice when product suitability, risk capacity, pensions, insurance or a large portfolio decision is unclear.
Seek tax advice before changing residence, extracting company cash, transferring assets, using trusts, gifting substantial sums or entering cross-border arrangements.
Seek legal advice before signing guarantees, shareholder agreements, acquisition contracts, complex leases, loan security or beneficiary arrangements.
Seek accounting advice when turnover, VAT, payroll, inventory, multiple activities or company-group transactions become material.
Use a defined written question. Paying for broad reassurance without documents or calculations rarely produces a useful answer.

16. Subject focus map

Use the following subject anchors as named checkpoints. For each checkpoint, record the fact, source, date, assumption, decision and next review date.
STRUCTURE PURPOSE: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
BENEFICIAL OWNERSHIP: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
GOVERNANCE: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
EXIT COST: define what this checkpoint means for this guide, what evidence supports it, and what result would cause you to change course.
Do not mark a checkpoint complete because an action was taken. Mark it complete only when the result and supporting evidence have been recorded.
Where a checkpoint depends on another person, institution, platform or contract, record that dependency and a fallback route.
Rank checkpoints by potential harm if ignored, not by how interesting or easy they appear.
At the end of each review, choose one checkpoint to advance and one risk to reduce before adding a new objective.

17. Worked decision case

Write a real decision from your own situation at the top of a blank page. Examples include changing work, launching an offer, choosing an account, buying an asset, restructuring a business or rejecting a proposal.
Baseline: state the current cash, income, liabilities, commitments, ownership, legal position and time available. Use documents rather than memory where possible.
Desired result: describe the measurable outcome, deadline and reason. Remove vague language such as more, better, passive, safe or guaranteed.
Options: include the proposed action, a smaller reversible test, a diversified alternative, delaying the action and doing nothing.
Evidence: attach at least three independent sources. Identify which evidence is official, contractual, audited, estimated, promotional or missing.
Economics: show setup cost, recurring cost, cash timing, fees, tax reserve, downside loss, opportunity cost and the point at which the decision becomes worthwhile.
Risk: identify concentration, liquidity, legal, operational, fraud, health, relationship and behavioural risks. Name the risk that could create irreversible harm.
Professional review: write the exact question that requires an accountant, lawyer, regulated adviser, lender, insurer or technical specialist.
Decision: state proceed, test, delay or reject. Record the maximum commitment and the evidence required before any further commitment.
Review: set a dated checkpoint. Write the result that would confirm the decision, the result that would require adjustment and the result that would trigger an immediate stop.

18. 90-day implementation workbook

Week 1 - Establish the baseline. Reconcile the relevant accounts, contracts, statements, fees, tax records, responsibilities and deadlines.
Week 2 - Define the result. Choose one measurable outcome and remove actions that do not directly support it or protect an essential risk.
Week 3 - Gather primary evidence. Use official registers, filings, signed terms, current quotations and dated institutional data.
Week 4 - Compare alternatives. Include a lower-cost option, a lower-risk option, a reversible test and the option to wait.
Week 5 - Model the economics. Build downside, base and upside cases while treating every uncertain input as an assumption.
Week 6 - Verify identity and authority. Confirm who owns, controls, advises, holds money, signs contracts and bears liability.
Week 7 - Run the smallest useful test. Limit money, time and legal commitment while collecting evidence about real demand or performance.
Week 8 - Reconcile actual results. Compare promised, expected and actual cost, time, cash flow, quality, risk and customer or counterparty behaviour.
Week 9 - Repair the constraint. Improve the single factor currently limiting income, retention, safety, liquidity, delivery or evidence quality.

18. 90-day implementation workbook (continued)

Week 10 - Install controls. Add calendar reminders, approval limits, account separation, written procedures, backups and review ownership.
Week 11 - Decide whether to scale. Increase commitment only when the test produced measurable value and the downside remains affordable.
Week 12 - Complete the evidence file. Store the decision record, sources, calculations, contracts, results, lessons and next review date.
Day 90 - Write a one-page conclusion: what was established, what remains uncertain, what changed, what will continue and what will stop.

19. Review, escalation and stop rules

Review monthly when the decision affects recurring cash, debt, customer commitments, investment contributions or essential protection.
Review immediately after a material legal change, tax notice, contract change, security incident, missed payment, large loss, health event or relationship change.
Escalate to a qualified professional when the facts cross jurisdictions, involve regulated products, create personal guarantees, affect beneficiaries or cannot be reversed cheaply.
Pause when required documents are missing, identities cannot be independently verified, costs are unclear or the counterparty resists reasonable due diligence.
Stop when the action requires deception, undeclared income, false invoices, hidden beneficial ownership, unaffordable leverage or essential-living money.
Stop when actual cash use, delivery time or loss exceeds the written limit.
Stop when the central evidence is corrected, withdrawn, contradicted by a stronger source or no longer current.
Do not move a stop limit merely because money, pride or time has already been committed. Sunk cost is not evidence that continuing is rational.
Record every exception to the plan, who approved it and why. Repeated exceptions indicate the plan or control is not working.
A stopped action can still be a successful decision when it prevents a larger loss and preserves the ability to act later.

20. Evidence and legal boundary

This is educational information, not personalised financial, investment, legal, accounting or tax advice.
Investments can fall in value. Businesses can fail. Debt, leverage, illiquidity, tax and legal obligations can create losses greater than the expected benefit.
Rules and thresholds change. Verify the current official position on the date of action.
Never use false invoices, hidden ownership, undeclared income, sham transactions, misleading applications or borrowed essential-living money.
No return, saving, valuation, tax outcome or business result is guaranteed.

21. Official research routes

1. Entreprendre.Service-Public.fr - Business creation - https://entreprendre.service-public.fr/
2. French business formalities portal - https://formalites.entreprises.gouv.fr/
3. BOFiP - French income tax bands - https://bofip.impots.gouv.fr/bofip/2491-PGP.html/identifiant=BOI-IR-LIQ-20-10-20260407
4. impots.gouv.fr - Investment income - https://www.impots.gouv.fr/particulier/les-revenus-mobiliers
5. SEC EDGAR - https://www.sec.gov/edgar/search/